All My Sons

By Arthur Miller

Time and Place: *The backyard of the Keller home in the outskirts of an American town, August, 1947.*

The Scene: *Chris (early twenties) professes his love for Ann (early twenties) and talks about the difficulty of resuming his life after the war.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: While war does occur between countries, it is carried out by people, by fellow human beings who should never have to bear witness to such extreme horrors. Many war films depict the brutalities of war, but it seems that these representations merely skim the surface. World Wars I and II, the Cold War, Vietnam, and the Gulf War and now the War in Iraq - millions of men fought, some survive and live among us today.

ACTRESS: Survivors, however, experience difficulty with feeling any strong emotion, particularly love. They often feel disconnected from reality, and guilty for having survived at all. In this scene Chris has returned home from WWII to make a life for himself and to forge a relationship with Ann, his brother's girlfriend.

ACTOR: My brother Lee is "missing in action," and life is too short for waste on "might have beens"

TOGETHER: All My Sons by Arthur Miller

CHRIS: *(Calling after him.)* Drink your tea, Casanova. *(He turns to Ann.)* Isn't he a great guy?

ANN: You're the only one I know who loves his parents!

CHRIS: I know. It went out of style, didn't it?

ANN: *(With a sudden touch of sadness.)* It's all right. It's a good thing. *(She looks about.)* You know? It's lovely here. The air is sweet.

CHRIS: *(Hopefully.)* You're not sorry you came?

ANN: Not sorry, no. But I'm...not going to stay...

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CHRIS: Why?

ANN: In the first place, your mother as much as told me to go

CHRIS: Well.

ANN: You saw that...and then you...you've been kind of...

CHRIS: What?

ANN: Well...kind of embarrassed ever since I got here.

CHRIS: The trouble is I planned on kind of sneaking up on you over a period of a week or so. But they take it for granted that we're all set.

ANN: I knew they would. Your mother anyway.

CHRIS: How did you know?

ANN: From her point of view, why else would I come?

CHRIS: Well...would you want to? *(Ann studies him.)* I guess you know this is why I asked you to come.

ANN: I guess this is why I came.

CHRIS: Ann, I love you. I love you a great deal. *(Finally.)* I love you. *(Pause. She waits.)* I have no imagination...that's all know to tell you. *(Ann, waiting ready.)* I'm embarrassing you. I didn't want to tell it to you here. I wanted some place we'd never been; a place where we'd be brand new to each other...You feel it's wrong here, don't you? This yard, this chair? I want you to be ready for me. I don't want to win you away from anything.

ANN: *(Putting her arms around him.)* Oh, Chris, I've been ready a long, long time!

CHRIS: Then he's gone forever. You're sure.

ANN: I almost got married two years ago.

CHRIS: ...why didn't you?

ANN: You started to write to me... *(Slight pause.)*

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CHRIS: You felt something that far back?

ANN: Every day since!

CHRIS: Ann, why didn't you let me know?

ANN: I was waiting for you, Chris. Till then you never wrote. And when you did, what did you say? You sure can be ambiguous, you know.

CHRIS: *(He looks toward house, then at her, trembling.)* Give me a kiss, Ann. Give me a... *(They kiss.)* God, I kissed you, Annie, I kissed Annie. How long, how long I've been waiting to kiss you!

ANN: *I'll never forgive you. Why did you wait all these years? All I've done is* sit and wonder if I was crazy for thinking of you.

CHRIS: Annie, we're going to live now! I'm going to make you so happy. *(He kisses her, but without their bodies touching.)*

ANN: *(A little embarrassed.)* Not like that you're not.

CHRIS: I kissed you...

ANN: Like Larry's brother. Do it like you, Chris. *(He breaks away from her abruptly.)*

ANN: What is it, Chris?

CHRIS: Let's drive some place...I want to be alone with you.

ANN: NO...what is it, Chris, your mother?

CHRIS: No... nothing Iike that...

ANN: Then what's wrong?..Even in your letters, there was something ashamed.

CHRIS: Yes. I suppose I have been. But it's going from me.

ANN: You've got to tell me

CHRIS: I don't know how to start. *(He takes her hand. He speaks quietly, factually at first.)*

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It wouldn't work this way. *(Slight pause.)* It's all mixed up with so many other things...You remember, overseas, I was in command of a company?

ANN: Yeah, sure.

CHRIS: Well, I lost them.

ANN: How many?

CHRIS: Just about all.

ANN: Oh, gee!

CHRIS: It takes a little time to toss that off. Because they weren't just men. For instance, one time it'd been raining several days and this kid came to me, and gave me his last pair of dry socks. Put them in my pocket. That's only a little thing...but...that's the kind of guys I had. They didn't die; they killed themselves for each other. I mean that exactly; a little more selfish and they'd've been here today. And I got an idea-watching them go down. Everything was being destroyed, see, but it seemed to me that one new thing was made. A kind of...responsibility. Man for man. You understand me?-To show that, to bring that on to the earth again like some kind of a monument and everyone would feel it standing there, behind him, and it would make a difference to him. *(Pause.)* And then I came home and it was incredible. I...there was no meaning in it here; the whole thing to them was a kind of a-bus accident. I went to work with Dad, and that rat race again. I felt...what you said...ashamed somehow. Because nobody was changed at all. It seemed to make suckers out of a lot of guys. I felt wrong to be alive, to open the bankbook, to drive the new car, to see the new refrigerator. I mean you can take those things out of a war, but when you drive that car you've got to know that it came out of the love a man can

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have for a man, you've got to be a little better because of that. Otherwise what you have is really loot, and there's blood on it. I didn't want to take any of it. And I guess that included you.

ANN: And you still feel that way?

CHRIS: I want you now, Annie.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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